

Same Event, Different Historian Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 30-40 min

Category	History	Time	30-40 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	same-event-different-historian

Big idea: Interpretation depends on lens and selection.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Same Event, Different Historian Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Same Event, Different Historian Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Two historians explaining the same protest, invention, or revolution differently. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Same Event, Different Historian Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Source packets that foreground economics, leadership, culture, or ordinary people. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Same Event, Different Historian Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A claim comparison chart: evidence used, emphasis, and implied values. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Interpretation depends on lens and selection.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Same Event, Different Historian Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Same Event, Different Historian Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Are some historical interpretations better than others?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Two historians explaining the same protest, invention, or revolution differently.
- Source packets that foreground economics, leadership, culture, or ordinary people.
- A claim comparison chart: evidence used, emphasis, and implied values.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to History.

Activity Steps

1. Assign each group a different lens.
2. Groups write a three-sentence explanation of the event.
3. Groups present and underline what they selected as important.
4. Students identify which facts were shared and which interpretations differed.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Are some historical interpretations better than others?
- Does perspective make history biased or meaningful?
- Can there be one true history?

Knowledge Questions

- Are some historical interpretations better than others?
- Does perspective make history biased or meaningful?
- Can there be one true history?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with two historians explaining the same protest, invention, or revolution differently. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...